

I heard this vort from my son-in-law Dovid Tribuch, who heard it from R' Ephraim Goldberg. When Avram leaves חרן and is coming to ארץ ישראל, Hashem gives him a tremendous הבטחה. וְאִם בִּנְיָיִךְ יִבְרָכְךָ וְאִם יִקְלָלְךָ וְאִם יִשְׁמָדְךָ וְאִם יִשְׁמָדְךָ וְאִם יִשְׁמָדְךָ (12:3). וְאִם בִּנְיָיִךְ יִבְרָכְךָ - whoever benches you; וְאִם יִקְלָלְךָ - will be benched, I will benched them. Both words are the same verb. However, וְאִם יִשְׁמָדְךָ - if they curse you, it doesn't say אַקלל, it says אָאָר, a completely different verb. What do we learn from that?

Rabbi Goldberg answers that if somebody benches us, Hashem will bench him. But if somebody curses us, what happens? Will that curse have any effect on us? What is כּלל ישראל's reaction to a curse? What is כּלל ישראל's reaction to any attack? We get together. Unfortunately, we've learned that the hard way. Despite our internal bickering, strife and fighting, if we're attacked, all of a sudden we are עם אחד, we get together, we unify. Hashem has to send us enemies to unify us. וּמְקַלְלֶךָ אָאָר can be translated as "I will make you shine" from the לשון of אור. When they curse you, you will shine. You will be great. You'll be unified and you'll bring out the best that's in כּלל ישראל. We don't curse anybody back. We become stronger, better, and we try to try to do תשובה and be better people.

This next vort has nothing to do with the previous one. When Avram and Sarah were going to מצרים, Avram noticed that Sarah is beautiful (12:12) וַיֵּהִי כַּאֲשֶׁר הִקְרִיב לְבֹא מִצְרָיִם וַיֹּאמֶר אֶל שָׂרִי אֵשֶׁתוֹ הִנֵּה נָא יְדַעְתִּי כִּי - Now I know that you are a beautiful, very attractive woman. Rashi says on these words מִדְּרַשׁ אֲגָדָה עַד עַכְשָׁיו לֹא הִכִּיר בָּהּ מִתּוֹךְ צָנִיעוּת שְׁבַשְׁנֵיהֶם - Avram did not recognize her beauty because of their modesty; וְעַכְשָׁיו הִכִּיר בָּהּ עַל יְדֵי מַעֲשֶׂה - But now he recognized it because they were in a situation where it will become an issue, become something to deal with.

The קשיא, which I saw in a sefer from Rav Pinchas Doron from ארץ ישראל, is that a חתן has to see his כלה at least one time before they get married. So Avram already recognized Sarah, he already knew of her beauty. So why is Avram saying now, הנה נא ידעתי כי אישה יפת מראה אַתְּ - Now I know you're beautiful. He knew that from before?

He gives a profound answer. A person can have beauty of various types. We are so used to recognizing the greatness and the majesty of אברהם אבינו, and all of us בני תורה don't recognize, at least not as on the spot, not as instinctively, the greatness and the majesty of שרה אמנו. Yes, we know that she's שרה אמנו, we know she's a נביאה, but not on that מדרגה אבינו. אברהם אבינו recognized שרה אמנו for the person that she was, for her inner strength and beauty. Her beauty did not lie in her externality, her beauty was internal, it was part of her מהות. Her majesty and beauty was something that Avram was so overwhelmed by that her external beauty paled in comparison. It didn't even affect him, he didn't even realize that she was beautiful, because she was such an outstanding, beautiful person. But now that they were coming to מצרים, where there were people whose only conception of importance was externality and superficiality, Avram said, "Uh oh, now we have to recognize this because it could cause an issue." Rashi is saying that it's only because of the מעשה that he now realized the greatness of her external beauty and said "We have to deal with it." But he really knew who she was what exactly what she looked like. She was such a majestic person that that her external beauty served absolutely no purpose in their relationship and they were wonderful together at a tremendously high level of majesty that we can all aspire to come to, all of us people today.

